fifteen-day period was over. However, we needed to ensure not only that the public heard it first from the Reserve Bank, but also that they got accurate information, which made it imperative to advance the press releases. Our staff coordinated overnight with the IMF and we issued press releases simultaneously, in the early morning of 3 November in Mumbai, and late evening 2 November in Washington.

This purchase of 200 tonnes of gold raised our gold holdings from 4.1 per cent of our forex reserves on 30 October 2009 to 6.7 per cent on 6 November 2009.

The manner in which the entire transaction was conducted in extreme secrecy and with utmost diligence, taking care at every step of the way to contractually protect India's interests, is a tribute to the competence, professionalism and integrity of the Reserve Bank staff under the overall guidance of Shyamala Gopinath. The *Financial Times* commended the Reserve Bank for putting through the deal 'like a hedge fund manager, leaving many countries red faced'. For me personally, it felt good to have pulled off such a complicated piece of theatre to conclude what some market experts labelled as the largest official deal in history.

The commentariat welcomed the gold transaction with enthusiasm and saw it as the Reserve Bank 'redeeming the honour' of the country nearly two decades after we were pushed into the ignominy of pledging gold to raise money to pay our foreign creditors. The *Guardian* of 4 November 2009 wrote: 'The deal underlines how India's economy has been transformed since 1991 when a financial crisis forced the country to take a loan from the IMF and ship its gold reserves to London as security.' And in an article titled 'India flexes its foreign reserve muscles', the *Financial Times* of 3 November 2009 reported Finance Minister Mukherjee describing the gold stock build-up as soothing the outrage that Indians had felt when 'we had to pledge gold to the Bank of England just for borrowing to support our imports'.

I was pleased with all the praise for the Reserve Bank's acumen but I was discomfited by compliments for me at a personal level, tempting though it was to believe that having signed away the pledge of gold back in 1991, I